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UC-Berkeley chancellor denounces Racial Privacy Initiative

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(*#_Company_Name_#*) BERKELEY, Calif. -- Chancellor Robert Berdahl spoke out against the Racial Privacy Initiative Wednesday, among other issues he discussed in his annual press conference.

"I think there are a lot of reasons why the Racial Privacy Initiative is a bad idea," he said. "The university and regents are committed to achieving diversity, and it seems to me, the achievement of diversity has to be measured in some fashion if we are committed to achieving that goal."

The Racial Privacy Initiative, set for the March 2004 ballot, would prohibit local and state government entities from collecting data on any individual based on "race, ethnicity, color or national origin in public education, public contracting and public employment."

Berdahl said he understood some of the concerns of the initiative's supporters, such as the complexity of defining race, but "not being able to identify the race or ethnicity of students makes it very difficult to measure any achievement or stated goals of the regents."

The implications of Berdahl's public opposition to the initiative remained open to debate among various figures.

Kevin Nguyen, the official proponent of the initiative and executive director of UC Regent Ward Connerly's organization, American Civil Rights Coalition, said Berdahl's statement was "not very surprising."

"Regardless of what the chancellors and the various academic senates and various associated student organizations do, it has been clearly shown in the Prop. 209 campaign that the voters aren't persuaded by those sentiments," he said. "We believe that it is going to play out in a similar fashion in the RPI campaign."

Connerly also initiated Proposition 209 in 1996, which prohibited affirmative action in state institutions.

But some UC Berkeley student leaders disagreed, saying Berdahl's opposition to the initiative would play a strong role in voter decisions in 2004.

"Berdahl is the chancellor of one of the flagship (UC) campuses, and by nature of his title, his expressing concern over RPI sends a strong message to the state," said Student Regent Dexter Ligot-Gordon. "He's an expert on higher education, and the voters listen to what experts have to say on implications on state institutions."

ASUC President Jesse Gabriel said Proposition 209 had "different circumstances and a different history" than the Racial Privacy Initiative.

Berdahl's comments come with the recent rise in opposition to the initiative.

Last weekend, the UC Student Assembly, a coalition of student governments from every UC campus, chose the opposition of the initiative as one of the three items on their action agenda for the 2002-03 academic year.

In the last UC Board of Regents meeting in July, Regent Cruz Bustamante asked the board to formally review the initiative in a future meeting.

Ligot-Gordon said he expects the regents to review the initiative within the academic year.

Other issues Berdahl discussed were student housing and UC divestment from businesses in Israel.

Although Berdahl said it would be a "long time before we are able to guarantee housing to all first- and second-year students," he said the new College-Durant complex, which houses 120 upper-division and graduate students was a big step toward his goal.

In addressing UC divestment from Israel, Berdahl said it was unlikely the regents would divest.

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